

**CAPSTONE RESEARCH PROJECT
TOPIC**

**THE ECONOMIC IMPACT OF INTERNATIONAL
IMMIGRANTS IN SYRACUSE**

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ABSTRACT

This study analyzes the economic impact of international immigrants in Syracuse, using primary survey data to investigate the relationship between human capital features, including educational attainment, English proficiency, profession, income, local spending, and civic engagement, and their contribution to the socio-economic development of the city.

Data were collected from 30 international immigrant respondents at five locations across Syracuse, including Destiny USA Mall, Walmart, North Salina Street, Syracuse University Avenue, and online. The sample comprised 63% male and 37% female respondents, representing 17 countries of origin from North America, Africa, the Middle East, and Asia. The most represented countries of origin were Somalia (27%), followed by Nigeria (10%), Turkey (7%), Yemen (7%), and Burundi 7%).

The sample demonstrated a relatively high level of educational attainment, with 37% holding a high school qualification, 33% Graduate degrees, and 23% Bachelor's degrees. English proficiency was also notably high, with 60% of respondents reporting an Advanced English level. The survey results showed varying income levels among immigrants. About 10% receive payments ranging from \$100 to \$500, whereas other respondents earn above \$3000. Regardless of whether immigrants report their income on a weekly or monthly basis, there is a substantial gap between earning levels. The findings revealed a mean income of \$1,531 and a median income of \$750. Additionally, 62% of respondents spend more than 50% of their income locally, confirming a strong and consistent economic contribution to Syracuse across all income levels.

The inter-variable analysis of the four key economic variables, including education, English proficiency, income, and percentage of income spent locally, reveals six pairwise relationships, all positive in direction.

These findings confirm that international immigrants make a considerable contribution to the local economy through their participation in the workforce, local spending, and civic engagement activities. Therefore, policymakers should implement financial support programs for low-income immigrants to help alleviate the burden of local expenses.

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CHAPTER ONE: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

In Syracuse, as in many other cities across the Great Lakes Region, population decline has been driven by several factors: the aging of the native-born population, the migration of younger native-born residents, and a shortage of jobs. According to Data USA (2024), the city's total population is 146,384. Within this population, foreign-born residents and diverse ethnic groups represent about 18,000, and create a cultural mosaic, positioning Syracuse as a significant hub for international immigrants in New York State.

The local workforce reflects both stability and significant gaps. Syracuse maintains approximately 62,600 job placements. The Healthcare and social assistance sectors have the largest hiring capacity, employing approximately 11,000 people. Educational services employ over 10,000 people, while the retail trade sector employs more than 7,000 workers. Despite these numbers, economic instability persists; the median household income in Syracuse is more than \$47,000, highlighting an unbalanced income distribution within the workforce (Data USA, 2024).

While the Syracuse Metropolitan Statistical Area offers more than 300,000 job opportunities, immigrants' representation remains less pronounced in high-growth sectors such as education, healthcare, manufacturing, and business, according to the New York Department of Labor (2026). Under current U.S. immigration laws, asylum seekers wait significantly longer for work authorization, from 150 to 365 days. Upon arrival, refugees can receive employment authorization that allows them to start working as soon as possible. They are eligible to apply for a green card and obtain permanent residency status after one year in the United States. They can also apply for U.S. citizenship after five years of residency (National Immigration Forum, 2025).

New immigrants' median wages can be estimated to be over \$15,000 per year in Upstate New York, and this tends to increase to approximately \$30,000 per year after five years.

To move beyond these aggregate statistics, this study uses raw survey data from 30 International immigrants living in Syracuse. This primary research aims to provide a comprehensive understanding of their economic impact and offer insights into public policy and community growth.

1.2 Problem Statement

Syracuse has been facing population decline and economic challenges due to an aging population and the outmigration of native-born citizens seeking opportunities in other regions. This research study seeks to demonstrate the value of foreign-born immigrants in helping fill the gap by contributing to the local economy, increasing the population and workforce, and providing important social benefits through their local spending and community service.

1.3 Research Questions

Research question 1: How does the workforce contribution of international immigrants positively impact the economic growth of Syracuse?

Research question 2: What are the factors that foster the labor-market integration of international immigrants in Syracuse?

Research question 3: To what extent can international immigrants' local spending and civic engagement activities improve social life in Syracuse?

1.4 Research Objectives

Main Objective:

The main objective of this research paper is:

- To analyze the economic impact of international immigrants in Syracuse through their human capital features, income outcomes, and civic engagement.

Specific Objectives:

- To examine the workforce integration of immigrants through the analysis of their profession, income, and local spending activities.
- To measure the income levels and payment patterns related to their educational backgrounds and earnings.
- To assess the extent to which immigrants are involved in community service and social participation in Syracuse.

1.5 Key Components

- Immigrant skills composition (education, English proficiency)
- Labor-market integration (time spent waiting for a job, income, profession)
- Local spending (transport, groceries, housing)
- Social participation (volunteerism)
- Duration in Syracuse

- Economic growth

1.6 Dependent Variables

- Time spent searching for a job after the settlement in Syracuse
- Income
- Local spending
- Social participation

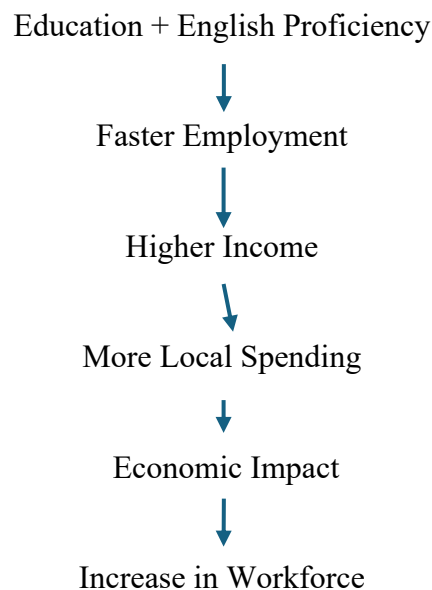
1.7 Independent Variables

- Educational attainment
- English proficiency
- Residence time in Syracuse
- Profession
- Control variables related to gender, age range, marital status, and country of origin

1.8 Hypotheses

- 1) **H1:** Immigrants with a higher educational background are likely to have shorter job search times upon arrival in Syracuse
- 2) **H2:** Immigrants who have a higher educational level tend to earn more income.
- 3) **H3:** Immigrants with higher incomes tend to spend more locally than those who earn less.
- 4) **H4:** Immigrants with low income also significantly contribute to local spending and social participation.

1.9 Logic Chain



1.10 Significance of the Study

This study uses empirical data to assess the economic impact of international immigrants in Syracuse. The primary survey data provides real-life evidence, adding value through new complementary raw data, and filling the gap in existing research that relies on census data. Furthermore, it offers experience-based recommendations for practitioners who may be interested in expanding the study of immigrants' economic contributions at the local, regional, or national level.

CHAPTER TWO: LITERATURE REVIEW

Introduction:

International immigrants play a considerable role in the demographic and economic growth of the Great Lakes region of the United States, specifically in areas experiencing population decline and manufacturing revalorization. This literature review on the topic: The Economic Impact of International Immigrants in Syracuse explores empirical studies and policy reports to measure how foreign-born residents contribute positively to population growth, economic trends, labor supply, and entrepreneurial initiatives, with a particular focus on Syracuse, New York. This literature review highlights the necessity of foreign-born labor forces as an alternative to population decline in areas with low population rates, demanding a high level of workforce through empirical and policy studies related to immigrants and economic growth. Some studies investigate and measure the direct effect of immigrants on populations experiencing population decline in some highly industrialized U.S. states with relatively low rates of population growth.

2.1 Immigration and Economic Growth

The working paper “Immigration and Economic Growth” by George J. Borjas (2019) examines the link between immigration streams and economic growth through a theoretical and empirical study that assesses the positive effect of high-skill employees on the labor market. His findings show that highly educated immigrants can positively contribute to increasing economic stability. He argues that immigrants’ economic support depends on technological innovation, human capital dynamism, and skill levels to increase output with a larger labor force. However, he focuses his studies primarily on the highly educated immigrants as a strength to reinforce the labor force in technology innovation and other skillful jobs. He does not report on the effects of less educated immigrants on the labor force.

Peri (2009), in his work about “The Effect of Immigration on Productivity: Evidence from U.S. States,” holds that immigration increases productivity and economic growth. He argues that immigration across the U.S. has fewer effects on native workers. Immigration fosters economic efficiency, particularly in technology and specialized fields. His findings prove that, rather than viewing immigration as a threat to native employees and a cause of reduced wages, it should be considered as an asset that augments the range of skills available and thereby improves productivity and income per worker. He adds that wage inflation has a smaller impact on native lower-skilled workers and a positive impact on highly educated immigrants.

In chapter 7 of *Metropolitan Growth and Migration: Estimation of the Model*, Greenwood (1981) examines the relationship between immigration flows and the economic growth of metropolitan areas. He argues that migration varies according to regional potentialities, particularly in terms of the opportunities available and the socioeconomic conditions of those areas. His empirical study identifies both the benefits and the consequences of post-World War II immigration trends in metropolitan areas. The analysis reinforces key elements of regional growth and decline. Greenwood also emphasizes that immigrants are valued according to their educational background, age, and work capacity, factors that shape the size and structure of metropolitan populations.

2.2 Immigrants in the Great Lakes Region and Syracuse

The policy report “New Americans and a New Direction: The Role of immigrants in Reviving the Great Lakes Region, published by New American Economy in partnership with Great Lakes Metro Chamber in 2017, analyzes the contribution of immigrants in revitalizing the Great Lakes region, historically known for its strong manufacturing base. Although the region has faced a population decline in recent decades, immigrants have contributed positively to its economic and demographic growth. The findings clearly indicate that immigrants play a key role in restoring demographic stability and supporting economic development. The report identifies immigrants as major contributors to the labor force, fiscal revenues, high-skilled STEM occupations, and business ownership. It highlights several sectors in which immigrants fill critical labor and skill gaps, supported by detailed statistical evidence. Furthermore, the report compares the age structure of immigrant and native-born populations, and it shows how immigrants help sustain workforce productivity in aging industrial areas by expanding the working-age population and supporting higher productivity.

New American Economy, through the policy report “New Americans in Buffalo and Syracuse: A Snapshot of the Demographic and Economic Contributions of Foreign-Born Residents in the Metropolitan Areas,” provides a detailed analysis of immigrants’ impact on the demographic dividend and fiscal contributions in Buffalo and Syracuse. The report presents significant positive economic findings, highlighting the role of immigrants in increasing population growth and regional GDP. It also shows how immigrants contribute to entrepreneurial activities and the strengthening of local housing markets. This report examines the demographic, economic, and

human capital contributions of foreign-born residents to improving livelihoods in Buffalo and Syracuse.

The report “How Immigration is Shaping US Cities, published by the American Immigration Council Staff in 2025, points out the role of immigrants in reinforcing the urban population of several cities, particularly the metropolitan areas between 2018 and 2023, such as Syracuse, NY, which has experienced native-born population loss. Immigrants account for a higher percentage of population growth, reaching nearly 45% of the population in metropolitan areas, with a percentage of 82.1 % in metro New York. Furthermore, immigrants have increased the workforce in several professional fields, accounting for more than 20% of the labor force in the 100 metro areas. They have served in key industries, healthcare, business, and technology. On top of that, immigrant households also play a significant role in increasing the local tax revenue of metropolitan areas, boosting the economy.

2.3 Labor Market Integration and Wage Effects

Borjas (2003), in his journal article “The Labor Demand Curve Is Downward Sloping: Reexamining the Impact of Immigration on the Labor Market,” reassesses the effect of immigration on the U.S. labor market by aggregating workers into national skill groups defined by education and work experience. He argues that city-level comparisons may distort the true wage effect of immigration because native workers can move across regions, which affects the estimated impact on wages. Therefore, he contends that the appropriate level of analysis is the national labor market for each skill group. His results show a clear negative relationship between immigration-driven growth in labor supply and wages. He finds that a 10 percent increase in the supply of workers in a skill group reduces the wages of that group by about 3 to 4 percent, especially for workers with low education and similar experience.

Lalonde and Topel (1991), in “Immigrants in the American Labor Market: Quality, Assimilation, and Distributional Effects,” analyze how immigrants’ educational attainment, talent, and English-language proficiency support their integration into the American labor force. They argue that immigrants’ countries of origin can influence how quickly they are incorporated into the labor market. They also find that, after settlement, immigrants gradually earn higher incomes as they become more immersed in the host country and gain work experience. The ability to distinguish themselves through their professional skills can reduce, though not eliminate, the wage gap between immigrants and native workers. In addition, they emphasize the distributional effects of

different types of immigrants, noting that varying levels of preparation and skills shape their position in the labor market. Their findings show that some groups arrive with lower levels of education and earn much less than native workers. Whereas highly educated immigrants are more likely to overcome initial disadvantages relatively quickly.

While foreign-born immigrants play a significant role in helping low-population areas grow and prosper, they may also have some negative effects on the productivity of low-skilled native-born residents, especially when low-skilled immigrants live in the same local labor markets. Their contribution to productivity is generally less pronounced than that of high-skilled immigrants. Some studies show that less-educated immigrants have only a modest impact on the overall labor market and the economic stability of U.S. cities. This is illustrated in the peer-reviewed journal article “Task Specialization, Immigration, and Wages” by Peri and Sparber (2009), who examine how the inflow of less-educated immigrants affects wages and task allocation among native-born workers with similar education levels. Their study shows that low-skilled immigrants and less-educated native-born workers are similar in observable skills, and wage reductions for natives are relatively small compared to the potential impact of high-skilled immigrants, who tend to be more privileged in the labor market. Conversely, Peri and Sparber (2009) argue that if less-educated immigrants and native-born employees learn different production tasks, native-born citizens can easily move into jobs that require more language skills than foreign-born immigrants, giving them an advantage in earning more income. Language barriers can be a challenge for immigrants, but these are partly offset by their comparative advantage in manual tasks.

In “Immigration and Inequality,” a lecture originally delivered by Richard T. Ely and analyzed through survey research by David Card (2009), the impact of immigration on U.S. wage disparities is examined. Card finds that immigrants have minimal effects on native wages because they largely occupy complementary roles rather than directly substituting for native workers, even when possessing similar skills. Wage competition is more pronounced among immigrants than between native- and foreign-born workers. Between 1980 and 2000, overall wage inequality increased by less than 6%, though job inequality may rise in skill-intensive sectors such as technology and trade. Low-educated workers can substitute for one another, whereas high school- and college-educated workers generally cannot. Moreover, there are no perfect substitutes between native-born and foreign-born employees, indicating that immigration has a limited effect on wage levels in the U.S. labor market.

2.4 Settlement Patterns and Urban Impact

Audrey Singer (2004), in “The Rise of New Immigrant Gateways,” provides a historical overview of immigrant settlement patterns in the United States from 1900 to 2000. She traces immigrants’ original destinations, such as New York, Chicago, and Los Angeles, and shows how these destinations shifted to new areas over time. For example, she notes that after 1970, immigrants moved from traditional cities to new metropolitan regions across the United States, which she categorizes into six different types of immigrant gateways. Her findings reveal that the immigrant population in the United States grew by over 55 percent during the 1990s and that, within a decade, roughly one in three immigrants settled in new destination states, particularly in the South and Mountain West, including states such as Georgia, North Carolina, Colorado, and Nevada. She also notes that between 1951 and 2000, six states, including New York, California, and Texas, were the top destinations for immigrants, and that more than half of all immigrants resided in those six states

CHAPTER THREE: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Introduction

This research study examines the socio-economic impact of international immigrants in Syracuse. The study uses primary data to assess the effectiveness of immigrants' economic contributions by examining their labor participation, entrepreneurial activity, and civic engagement, as influenced by their education level, English proficiency, and the time it takes to find a job after arrival in Syracuse. The value of immigrants' labor fosters local market integration by shaping how quickly they secure employment and how well their skills align with local opportunities. The study also identifies the extent to which their income is reinvested locally through housing, transportation, groceries, and services. The results indicate that immigrants with higher levels of education, stronger English proficiency, and a longer period of residence in Syracuse have greater labor-market impact, higher incomes, and higher levels of local spending. Moreover, the findings highlight that immigrants with lower levels of formal education also make significant contributions to the labor market and local demand.

3.1 Human Capital Theory

Human Capital Theory, originally studied by Becker (1964), constitutes the primary theoretical foundation of this study. It claims that people who invest in education and language proficiency foster their earnings and productivity in the workforce.

Mincer (1974) further developed Human Capital Theory through the "Human Capital Earnings Function, arguing that individual earnings are shaped through the investments in both education and professional experience, providing a quantitative framework for assessing the economic returns to human capital contribution. It reflects training and skill reinforcement, developing experience more than age. He argues that unobserved factors not handled may impact earnings inequality for roughly two-thirds of the human capital.

Regarding this study, both Becker's and Mincer's theoretical predictions are partially supported by the results. The correlation between education and English proficiency ($r=0.33$) proves that educational attainment improves language skills, while the positive relationship between education and income ($r=0.31$) confirms that higher human capital investment is related to Mincer's statement that unobserved elements may account for a considerable proportion of income inequality among international immigrants in Syracuse.

3.2 Social Integration Theory

Social Integration, developed by Emile Durkheim, claims that the value of a society depends on the extent to which its people are integrated through social relationships. He describes through the division of labor in society that traditional societies are connected through organic solidarity. He argues that individuals become more interrelated through their different responsibilities in society. This theory helps grasp how international immigrants contribute to and integrate into a new place through labor-market, civic engagement, and economic contribution.

A central prediction of Social Integration Theory is that immigrants who succeed easily will build stronger relationships with their host communities, leading to higher civic engagement and local spending outcomes. This is connected to the findings of this study, where 62% of respondents spend more than 50% of their income locally. This shows that economic integration translates into considerable local economic contribution. The theory also explains the role of civic engagement in increasing economic integration. The finding that 37% of participants actively volunteer in mosques, refugee associations, schools, and community organizations confirms that economic and social integration define the role of international immigrants in Syracuse.

3.3 Conceptual Framework Diagram

Both theoretical frameworks described above contribute to an integrated conceptual analytical approach. Human Capital Theory identifies education and English proficiency as the primary human capital strengths that lead to income outcomes. Social Integration Theory shows how profit creation relates to local spending and civic engagement. The four key variables are analyzed through the inter-variable correlation analysis and a path diagram in Chapter 5, as illustrated in Figures 17 and 18.

CHAPTER FOUR: METHODOLOGY

Introduction:

In the Seventh edition of the book “Research Methods for Public Administrators”, Russel et al. (2021) define research methodology as an organized study plan that includes structured research techniques for data analysis and the presentation of the results, and whose finality is to succeed in providing a complete quality project.

This section describes the methods and procedures used to conduct this study. This research design is a mixed-method approach with a primarily quantitative approach that has a structured, closed-ended questionnaire and a small qualitative component through an open-ended follow-up question. It describes the research design, research population, research location, sample and sampling technique, research instrument, data collection procedures, data analysis, data quality and missing data, ethical considerations, and limitations of the study.

4.1 Research Design:

According to Russel et al. (2021), a research design provides a systematic plan for collecting and analyzing data in alignment with the research objectives and questions. Guided by this definition, this study used a survey research questionnaire elaborated using Google Forms to collect primary data to examine the economic contribution of immigrants in Syracuse through their employment patterns, income levels, local spending, and civic engagement activities.

4.2 Research Population

The target population of this research comprises international immigrants living and working in Syracuse. The research survey instrument examined their economic contribution by focusing on their earnings, local spending, and volunteering activities to measure the impact of their presence in the city.

4.3 Research Location

The data collection of this research took place at five sites strategically selected to reach foreign-born residents throughout the city, such as North Salina Street (commercial corridor), Destiny USA Mall, Syracuse University Avenue, Walmart, and Online to reach respondents unable to participate in person. These locations were chosen to ensure geographic diversity and to maximize participation from foreign-born residents across various neighborhoods and socioeconomic backgrounds.

**Fig 1 • Survey Data Collection Locations in Syracuse, NY
The Economic Impact of Foreign-Born Residents (n=30)**

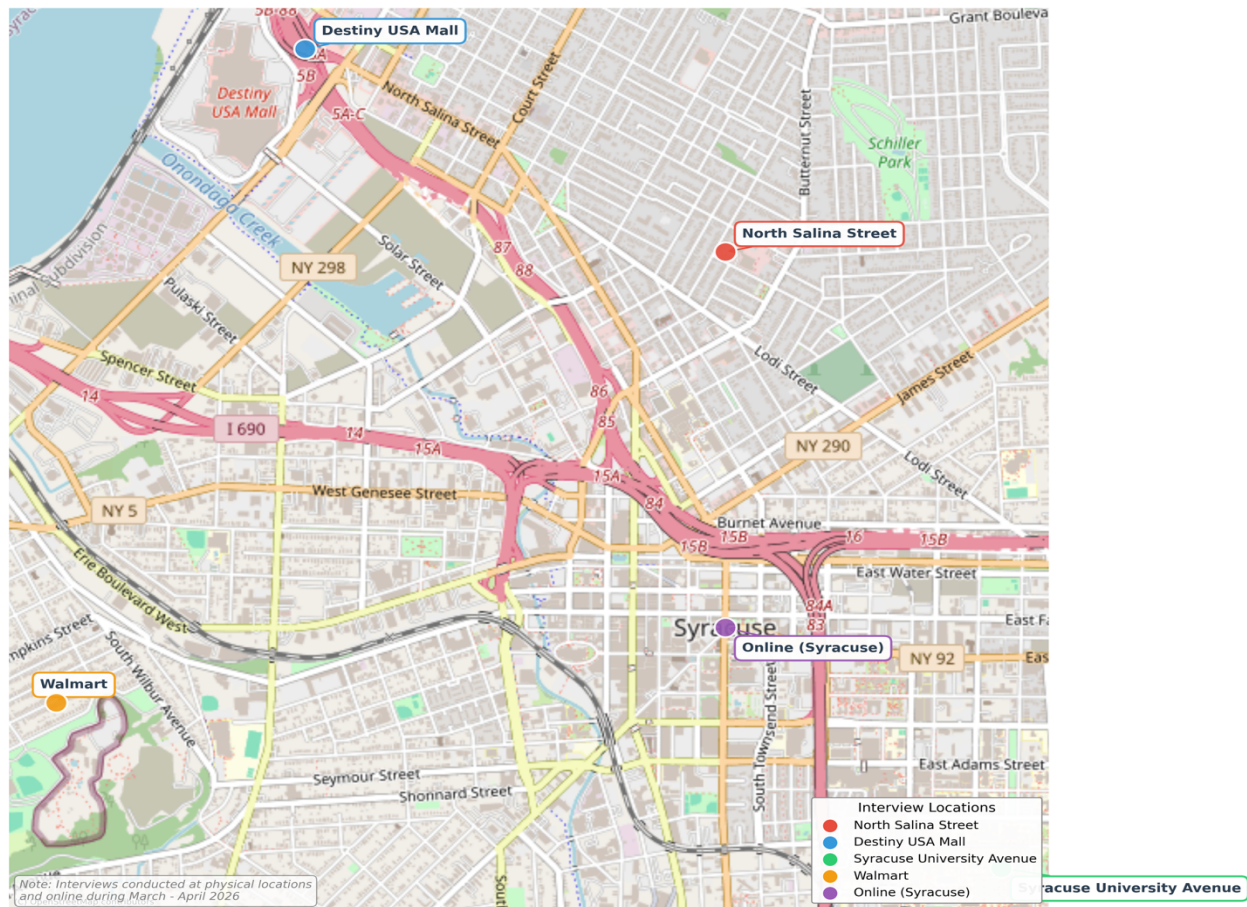


Figure 1: Data Collection Location

4.4 Sample and Sampling Techniques:

This research sample and sampling technique only focused on foreign-born residents of Syracuse who have a job and earn an income. Among the wide range of international immigrants from many nationalities, only 30 people responded to the questionnaire due to the fear of the current U.S. government immigration policy. Most of the participants were not willing to take part in the research survey.

4.5 Research Instrument:

The research instrument used to conduct this research is a survey questionnaire of 17 questions, and most of them have structured and categorical responses that can be counted and statistically analyzed. The survey questionnaire provides demographic categories, educational information, English proficiency, income range, percentage of income spent locally, time to find a job,

frequency of income payment, and a small section of qualitative questions related to volunteer activities.

4.6 Data Collection Procedures:

This study adopted a mixed methods approach, predominantly quantitative in nature, with supplementary qualitative open-ended questions examining civic engagement activities. According to Johnson et al. (2007), mixed methods research involves the integration of both quantitative and qualitative approaches within a single study to provide a more comprehensive understanding of the research project.

A comprehensive literature review of 10 sources on working papers and policy reports was conducted to synthesize existing empirical evidence on the socio-economic impact of international immigrants in Syracuse and Onondaga, the Great Lakes Region, and the U.S. in general.

4.7 Data Analysis:

In this research paper, Google Forms automatically stored all survey responses in both Excel and CSV formats, facilitating data export for subsequent analysis. The researcher used Python to conduct quantitative analysis and generate all data visualizations presented in the study.

Data Quality and Missing Data

An examination of the survey dataset revealed minimal missing data across four variables, as presented, and four respondents (13%) did not report their number of children. Income and percentage of income spent locally each recorded one missing response (3%). All missing data rates remained below 15% threshold considered acceptable in survey research (Enders, 2003, as cited in Dong & Peng, 2013). Missing values were excluded from the data analysis.

Fig 2 • Missing Data Summary — Survey Respondents (n=30)

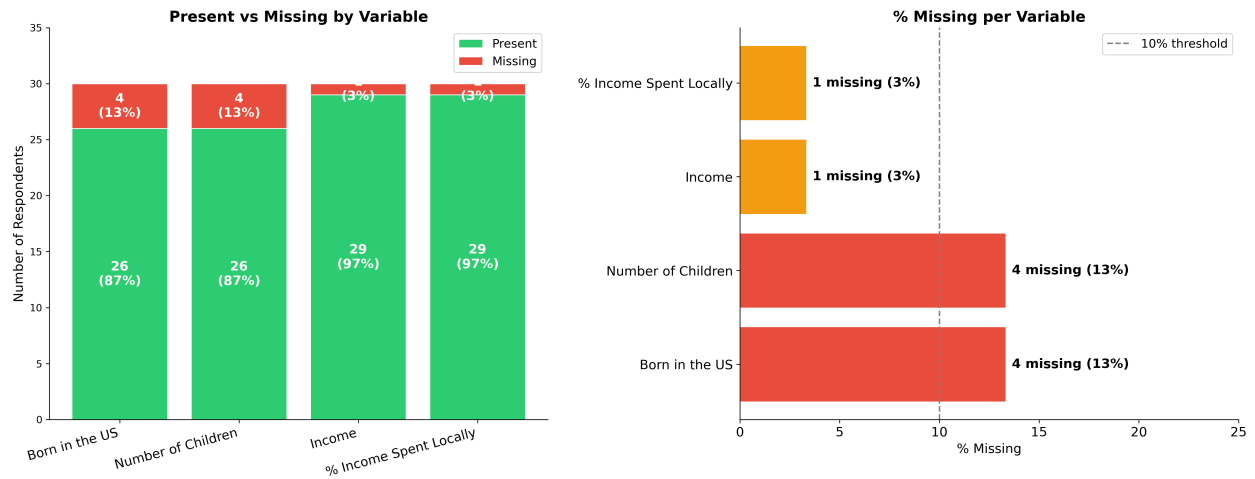


Figure 2: Missing Data Summary

4.8 Ethical Considerations:

Participation in the survey research was voluntary. Participants' identities were kept anonymous.

4.10 Limitations of the Study:

This study is limited by a relatively small sample size of 30 international immigrants. Furthermore, a small number of native-born residents completed the survey questionnaire, but their responses were excluded from the final dataset before analysis as they did not meet the eligibility criteria for this study. This small sample size may be partially attributed to the current U.S. immigration policy, which may have created apprehension among potential respondents and limited their willingness to participate in this study.

CHAPTER FIVE: RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS

Introduction:

This section presents the results, analysis, and interpretation. The questionnaire is composed of 17 questions, of which most are closed-ended questions, and a small section of an open-ended follow-up question. The data collected is small; only 30 participants responded to the questionnaire, which asked for their demographic background, their countries of origin, their education and English language proficiency, the arrival time in Syracuse, the time spent before finding a job, their income, their local spending, and their volunteering activities.

5.1 Results Presentation and Interpretation:

Survey Research for Foreign-born workers in Syracuse

Question No. 1: What is your gender?

Table 1: Distribution of Respondents by Gender

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Male	19	63%
Female	11	37%

Note: All participants responded to this question. Of the respondents, 63% are male, and 37% are female.

Question No. 2: Were you born in the U.S?

Table 2: U.S. Birth Status of Participants

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Yes	2	7.7%
No	24	92%

Note: This question was answered by 24 respondents who said “No”, and 2 respondents who said “Yes”.

Question No. 3: What is your marital status?

Table 3: Marital Status of Respondents

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Married	19	63%
Engaged	1	4%
Single	10	33%

Note: From the 30 respondents, 63% said they are married, 33% are single, and 4% are engaged.

Question No. 4: Do you have children?

Table 4: Parental Status of Participants

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Yes	17	57%
No	13	43%

Note: This question reveals that 57% of respondents have children and 43% do not.

Question No. 5: If yes, how many do you have?

Table 5: Number of Children

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
5 or plus	5	19%
3 to 5	3	11%
1 to 2	9	33%
No, None and No children	3	11.1%
0	7	26%
Empty columns	3	N/A

Note: Up to 19% have five or more children, 11% have 3 to 5 children, 33% have 1 to 2 children. All remaining responses are additional comments from respondents who confirmed that they do not have children.

Question No. 6: How old are you?

Table 6: Age Distribution of Survey Participants

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
50 +	5	17%
35 - 49	5	17%
25 - 34	15	50%
18 - 24	4	13%
15 +	1	3%

Note: Respondents come from different age groups: 17% are 50 years old or older, 17% are 35 to 49 years old, 50% are 25 to 34 years old, and only 1 (3.3%) is 15 years old or older.

Fig 3 • Demographic Profile of Survey Respondents (n=30)

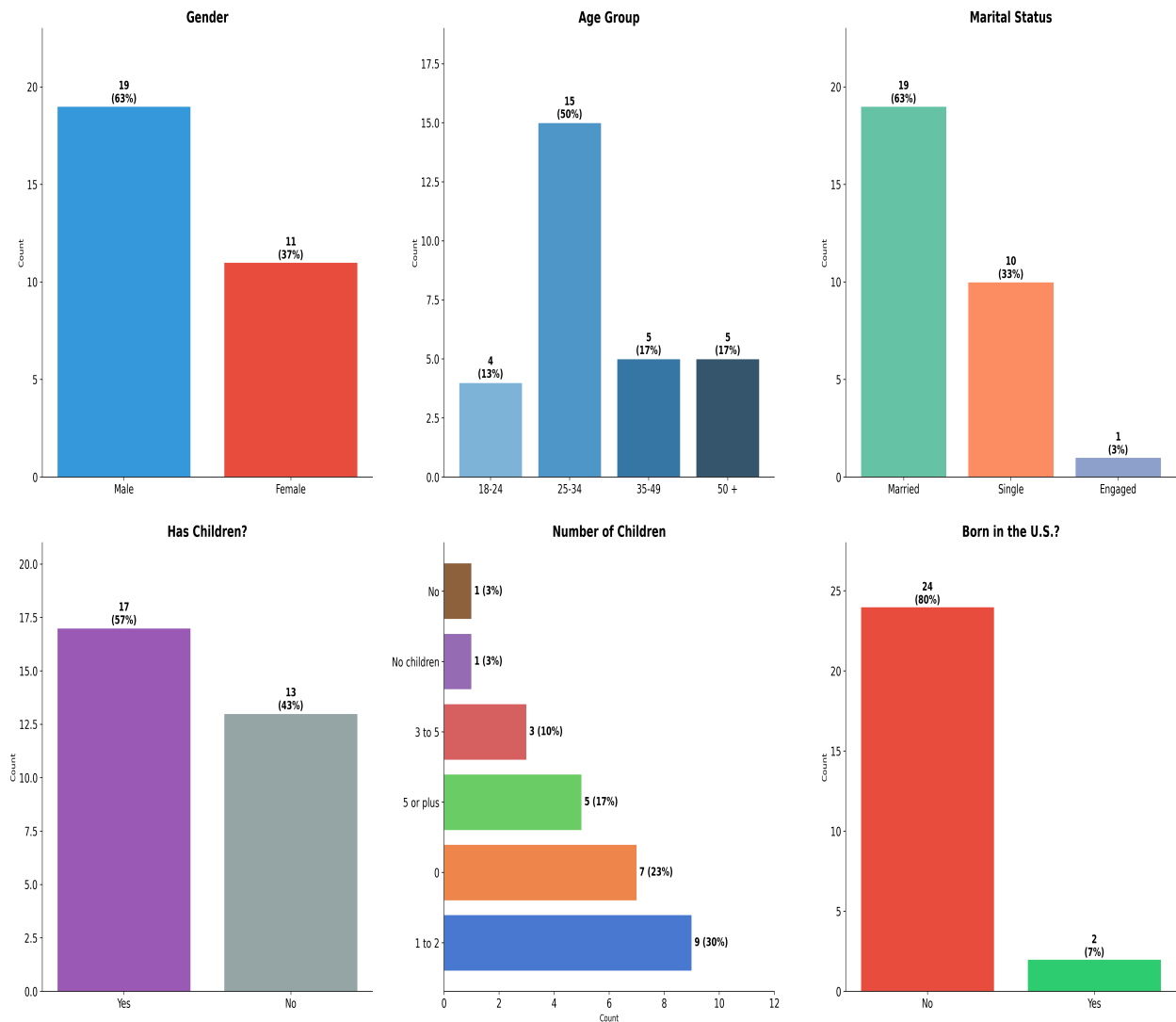


Figure 3: Demographic Profile of Respondents

Question No. 7: What is your country of origin?

Table 7: Participants' Countries of Origin

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Somalia	8	27%
Burundi	2	7%%
Nigeria	3	10%
Yemen	2	7%
Turkey	2	7%
South Korea	2	3%
Indonesia	1	3%
India	1	3%
Iraq	1	3%
Afghanistan	1	3%
Syria	1	3%
Ghana	1	3%
Haiti	1	3%
Cuba	1	3%
Pakistan	1	3%
Tanzania	1	3%
Bangladesh	1	3%

Note: Respondents come from 17 international countries, including North America, Africa, the Middle East, and Asia. Somalia is the top country with a record of 8 participants, followed by Nigeria with 3 participants, and four additional countries, Cuba, Yemen, Burundi, and Turkey, each with 2 participants. The remaining 11 countries recorded only 1 participant each.

Fig 4 · Countries of Origin of Foreign-Born Residents in Syracuse, NY (n=30)

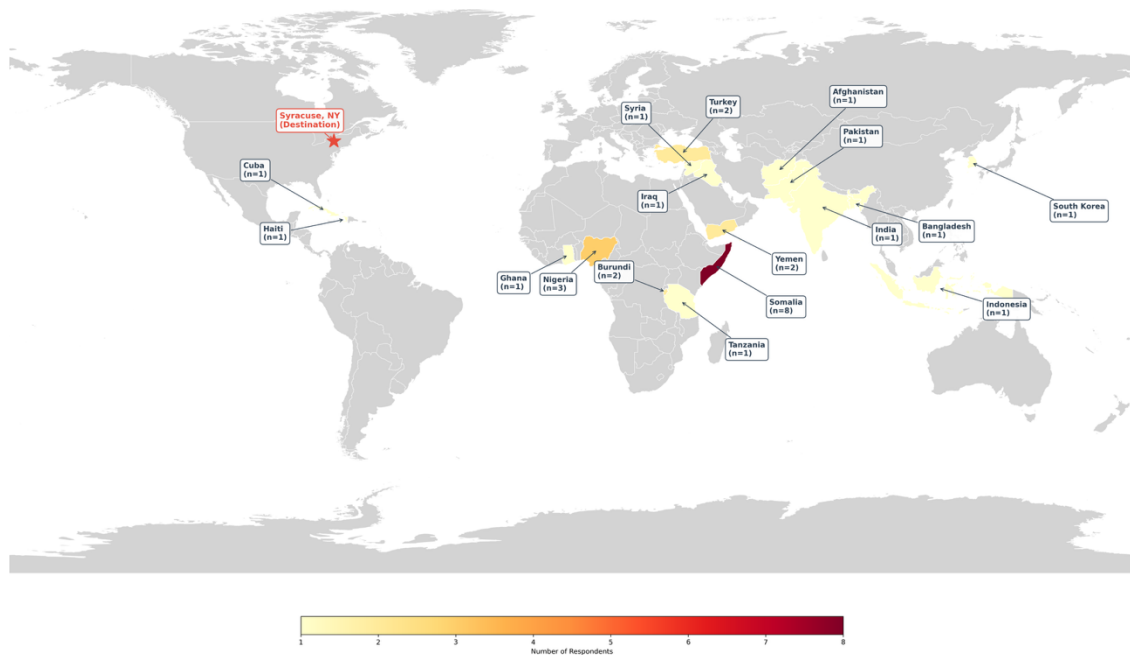


Figure 4: Immigrants' Countries of Origin

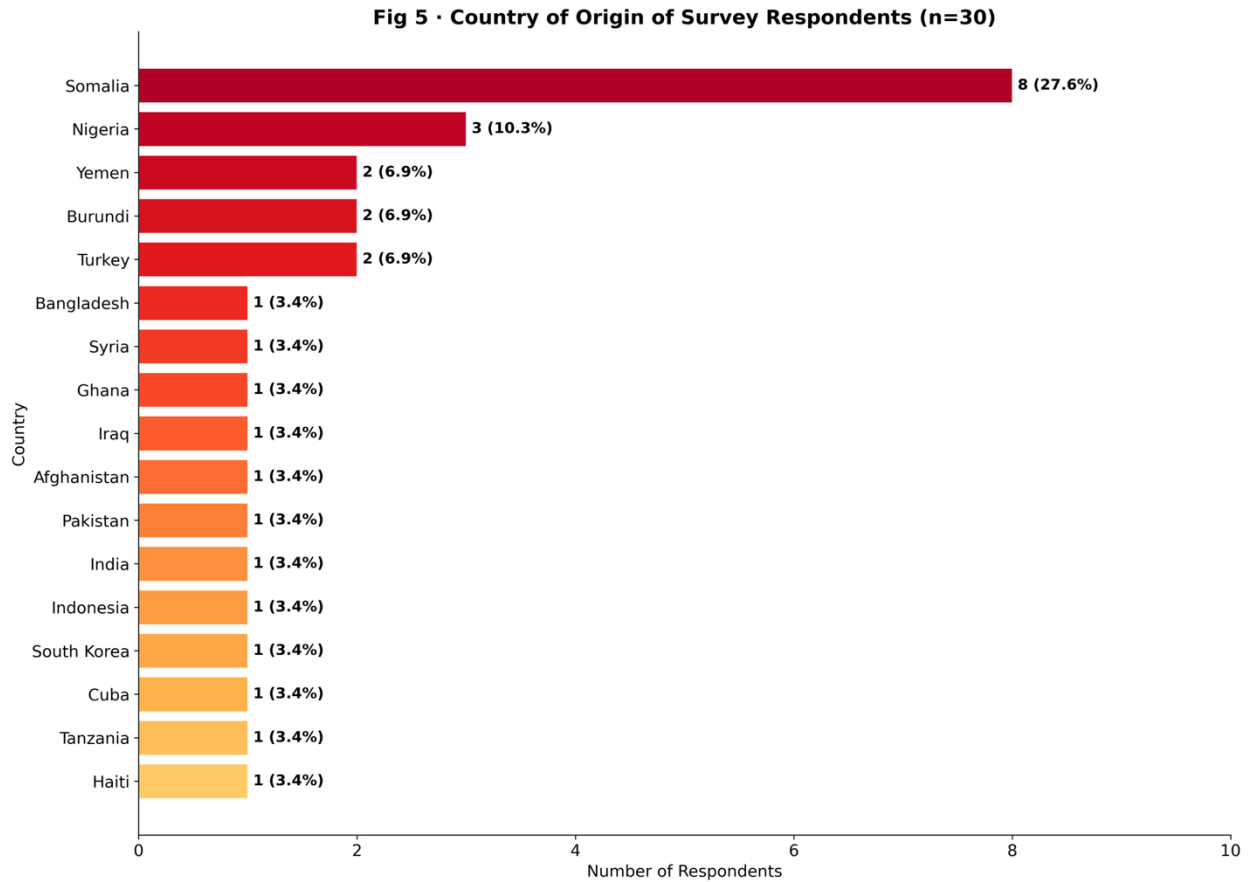


Figure 5: Chart of Countries of Origin

Question No. 8: What is your educational level?

Table 8: Educational Attainment of Respondents

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Graduate Degree	10	33%
Bachelor's	7	23%
High School	11	37%
Middle High School	2	6.7%

Note: The survey research reveals that 33% of respondents have a graduate level education, 23% have a Bachelor's degree, 37% have a High School education, and 6.7% have a Middle High School educational background.

Question No 9: What is your English skill proficiency?

Table 9: English Proficiency Levels

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Advanced	18	60%
Intermediate	9	30%
Basic	3	10%

Note: Participants show a higher level of English proficiency, with 60% saying they have an advanced English level, 30% intermediate, and 10% with basic level.

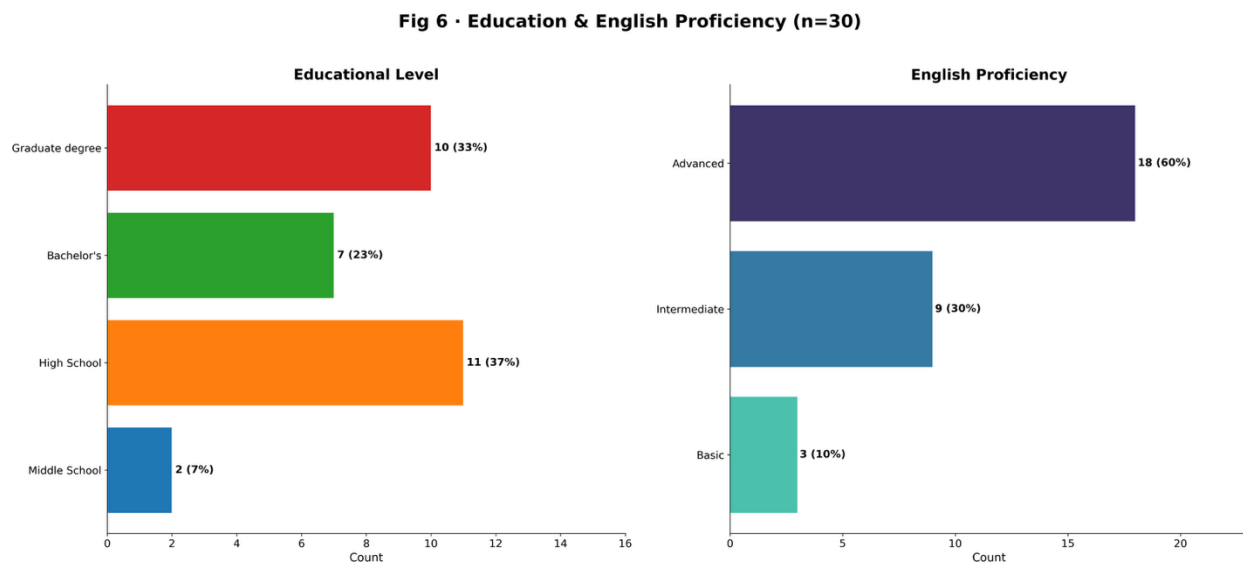


Figure 6: Education and English Proficiency

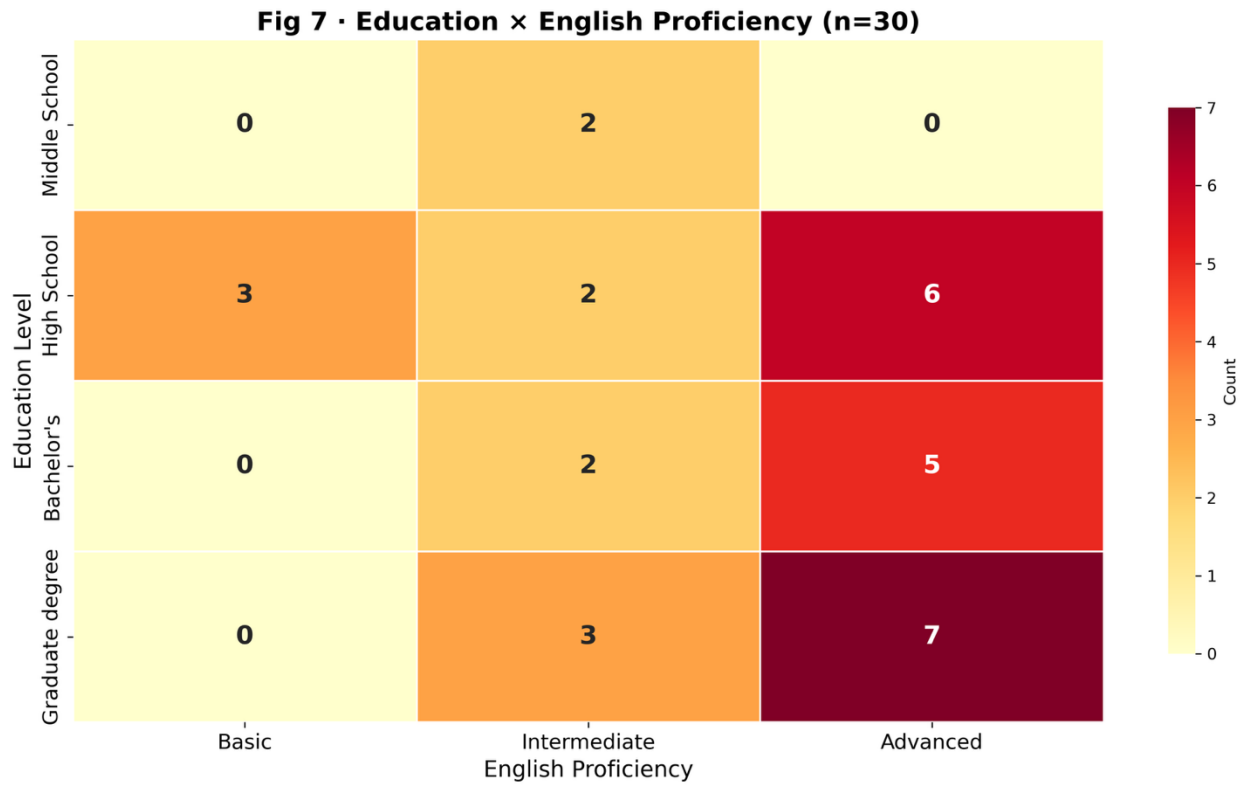


Figure 7: Education versus English Proficiency

Question No. 10: When did you arrive in Syracuse?

Table 10: Duration of Residence in Syracuse

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Less than one year	4	13%
One year	4	13%
Two years	2	6.7%
Three years	5	17%
Four years	4	13%
Five years	0	3%
Seven years	1	3%

Nine years	1	3%
Twelve years	1	3%
Fifteen years	1	3%
Seventeen years	2	7%
Eighteen years	1	3%
Twenty years	2	7%
More than twenty years	1	3%

Note: The survey respondents have varied arrival times. While some have lived in Syracuse for more than 20 years, others have been here for less than a year and have already found employment.

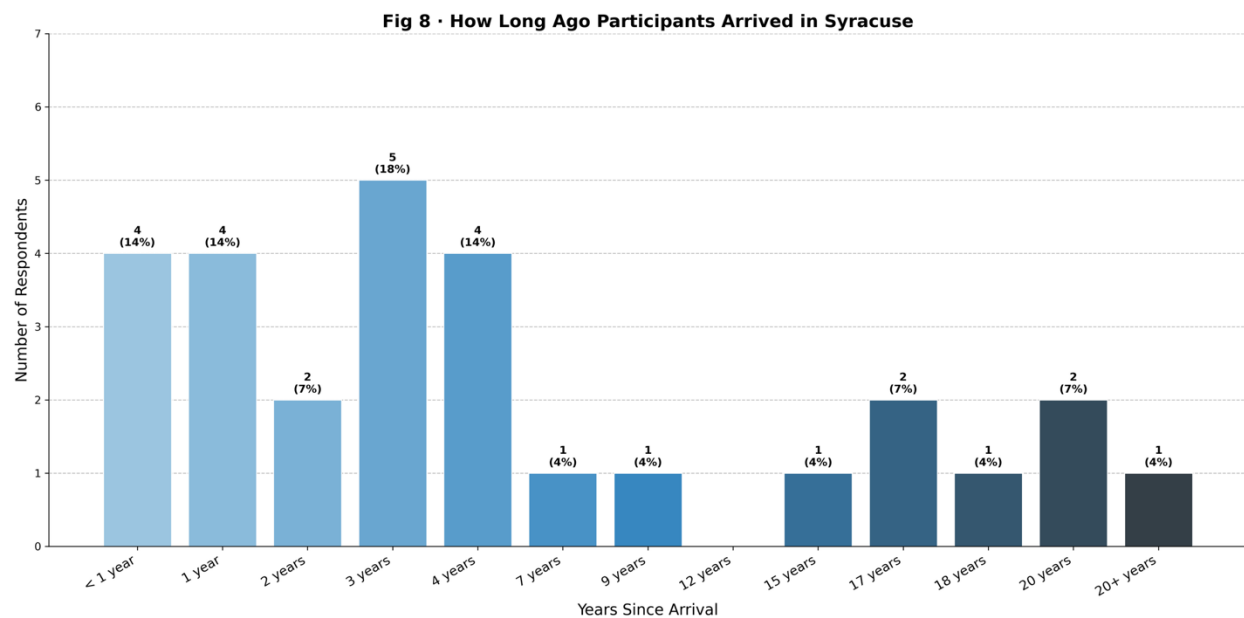


Figure 8: Respondents' Arrival Time in Syracuse

Question No. 11: What is your profession?

Table 11: Employment

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Employee in the private sector	12	40%
Employee in the public sector	9	30%
Business owner	5	17%
Uber, civil engineering	1	3%
Sales	1	3%
Tiling work	1	3%
Student employee	1	3%

Note: Most respondents work in the private sector, accounting for 12%, while the public sector recorded 30%. Business owners and respondents who specified other work areas make up the remaining percentage. Overall, this reflects a reasonable balance, as both sectors are well represented.

Fig 9 · Employment (n=30)

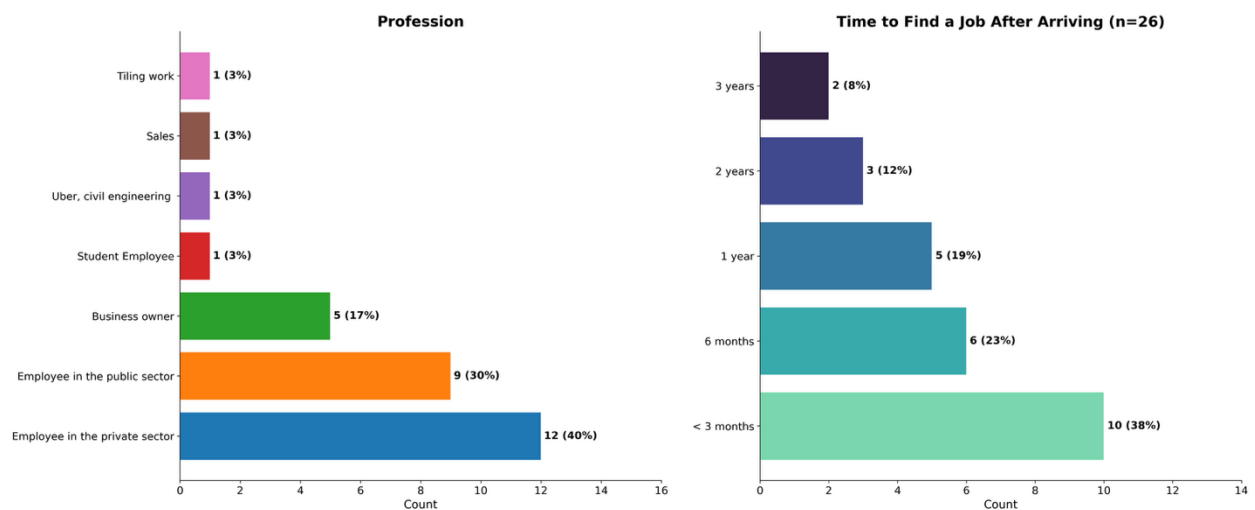


Figure 9: Employment

Question No. 12: After arriving in Syracuse, how long does it take to find a job?

Table 12: Timeframe for Securing Employment After Arrival

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Less than three months	10	33%
Six months	6	20%
One year	5	17%
Two years	3	10%
Three years	2	7%
Other	4	13%

Note: 26 respondents gave a valid response. Of these, 33% spent less than three months before finding a job. Some (20%) spent six months, 17% spent one year. Additionally, 7% mentioned spending three years. The remaining four respondents provided context-specific answers rather than a timeframe, such as: “I was twelve years old when I arrived”. “I moved when I was eight, I grew up here and started working at 17.” “I arrived in Syracuse after finding a job”, and “Visiting.”

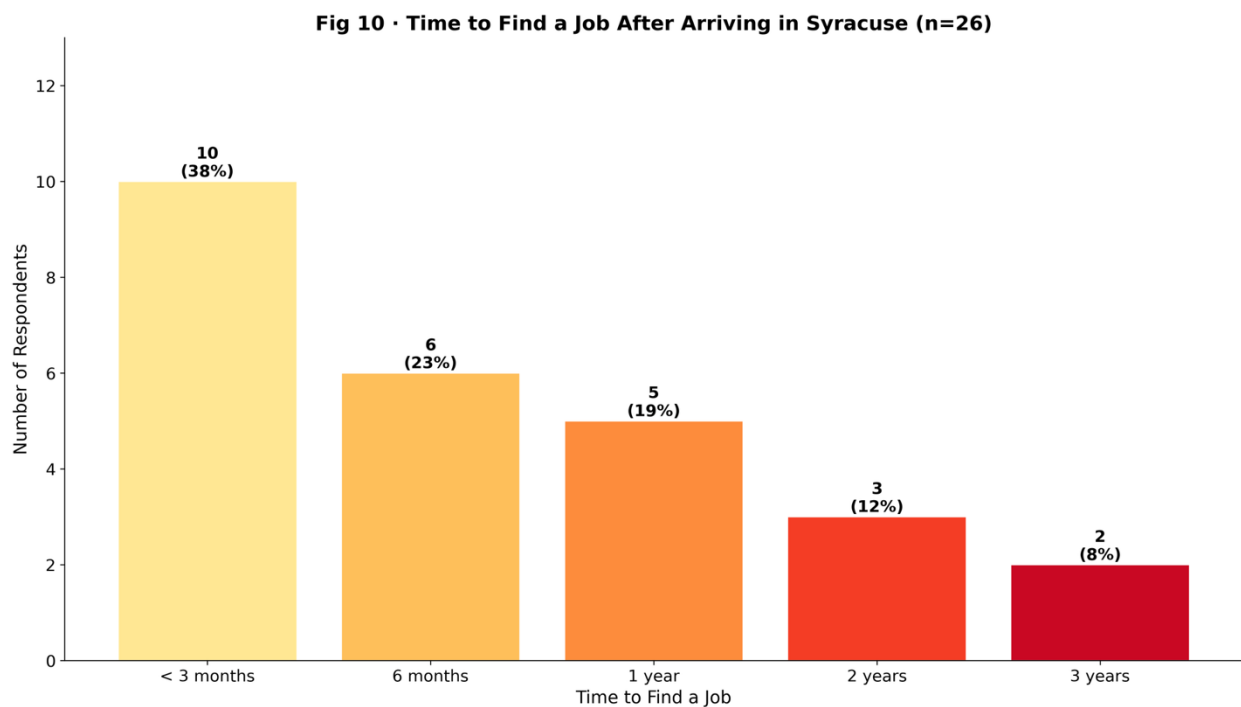


Figure 10: Time to Find a job After Arrival

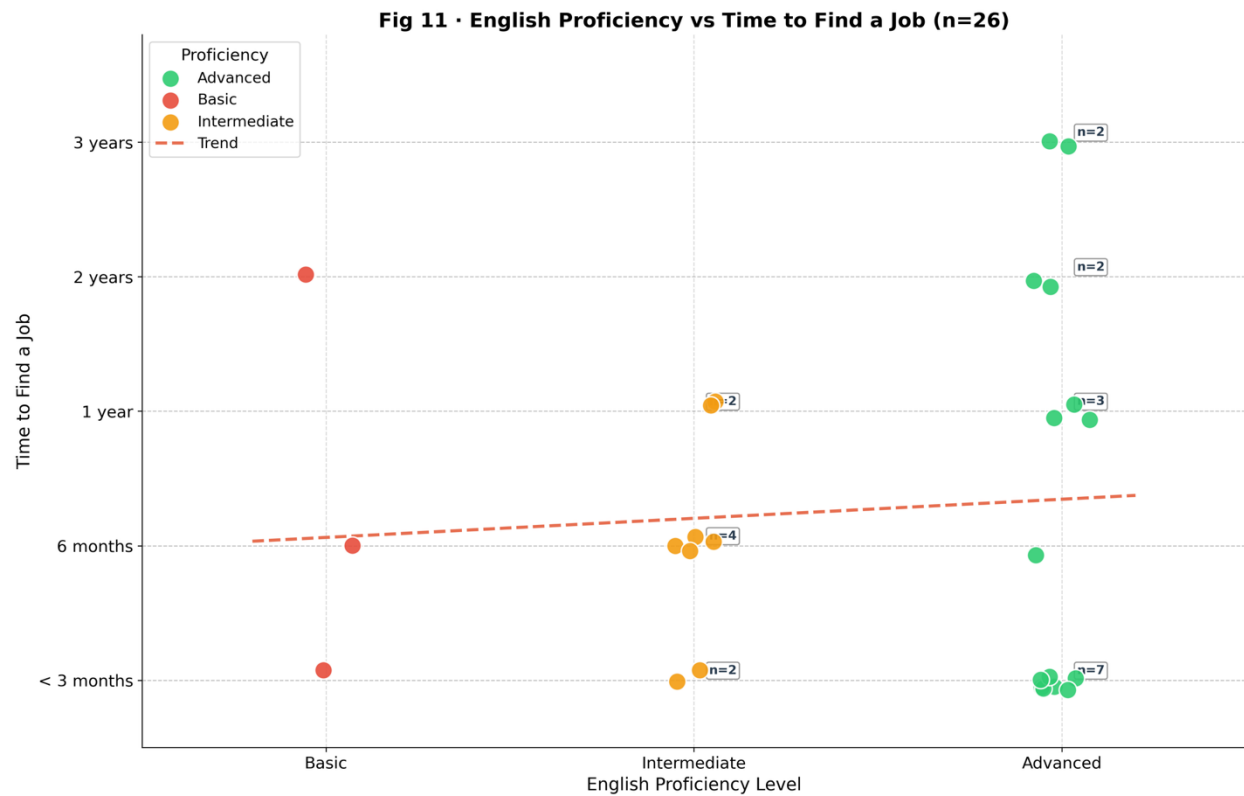


Figure 11: English Proficiency versus Time to Find a Job

Question No. 13: What is the frequency of your income payment?

Table 13: Frequency of Income

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Yearly	0	0%
Monthly	9	30%
Weekly	21	70%
Daily	0	0%

Note: The results reveal that respondents have a weekly 70% and a monthly 30% income payment.

Question No. 14: How much do you earn as income?

Table 14: Income Distribution

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
\$3000 or more	9	31%
\$1000 to \$2000	5	17%
\$500 to \$1000	12	38%
Weekly \$500 to \$1000	1	3%
\$100 to 500	3	10%

Note: The survey shows that the largest group of respondents earns between \$500 and \$1000, representing 72%, including one respondent who specified a “weekly payment of \$500 to \$1000. Those who earn \$3000 or more represent 31%. Respondents who earn \$1000 to \$2000 account for 17%, and those who earn between \$100 to \$500 represent 10% of the survey population.

Question N 15: Approximately, what percentage of your income is spent locally (housing, groceries, transportation, services in Syracuse)?

Table 15: Percentage of Income Spent Locally

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
76 – 100%	9	31%
51 – 75%	9	31%
26 – 50 %	6	21%
25% or less	5	17%

Note: Respondents reported varying local spending frequencies, with most spending more than 50% of their income locally. Both the 51-75% range (31%) and the 76-100% (31%) range each account for 31% of respondents, meaning that combined, 62% of respondents spend more than half of their income locally.

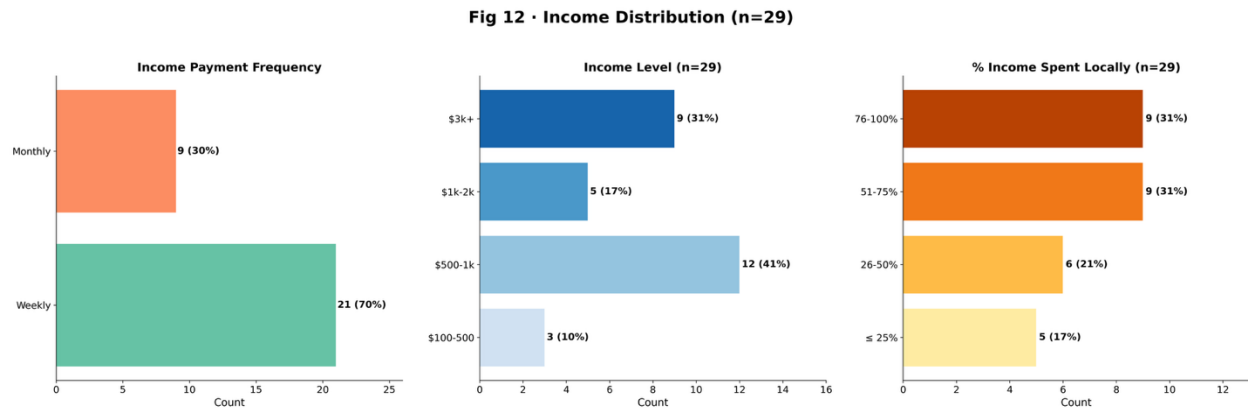


Figure 12: Income Distribution

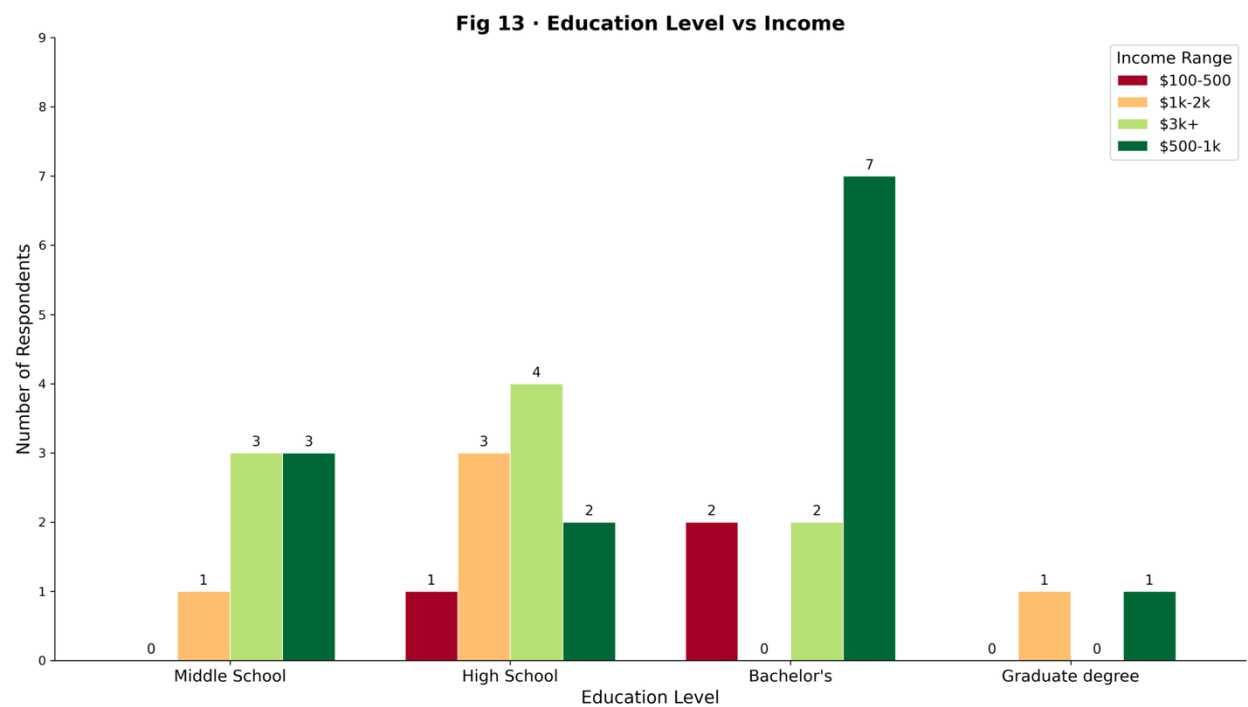


Figure 13: Education level versus Income

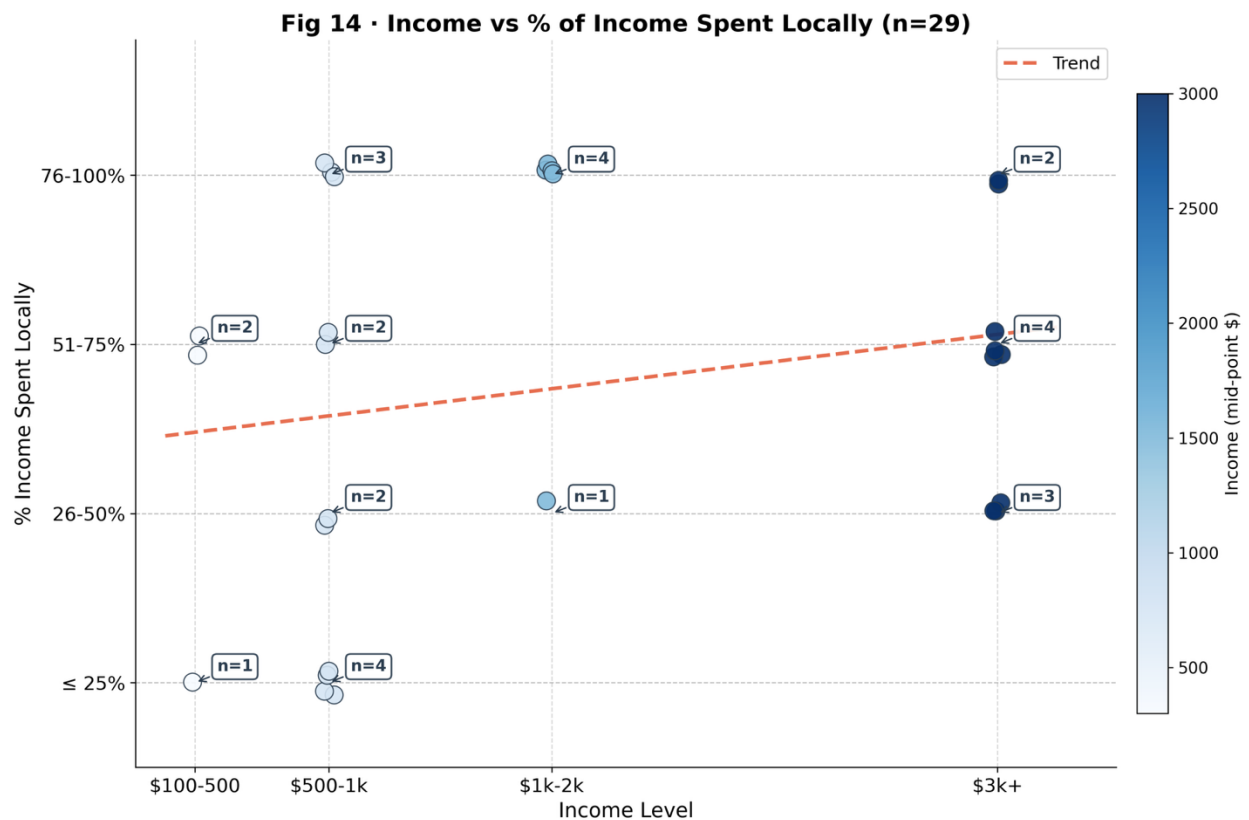


Figure 14: Income Level vs Percentage of Income Spent Locally

Question N 16: Do you currently volunteer in any community service activities?

Table 16: Community Volunteerism

RESPONSE	COUNT	PERCENTAGE
Yes	11	37%
No	19	63%

Note: This response reveals that 37% said “yes” to community volunteerism and 63% indicated that they are not involved in community service activities.

Question No. 17: If yes, please specify.

Table 17: Respondents Community Volunteering

RESPONSE	COUNT
100 Black Men Inc	1
I would love to. However, with family of 4, wife does not speak English - life is so busy and full of challenges, and opportunities.	1
Somali- Bantu Refugees Community Association	1
Masjid Bilal	2
North Side Learning Center	1
Military	1
Teaching our culture orientation	1
Sometimes for my child's school	1
I help drop off people with my car when they need help.	1
Mycanord Datus	1
Syracuse Turkish Community	1
Helping for clean environment	1

Note: 13 respondents provided their perspectives on their volunteer activities. The findings indicate that some make meaningful social contributions.

Fig 15 • Community Volunteering (n=30)

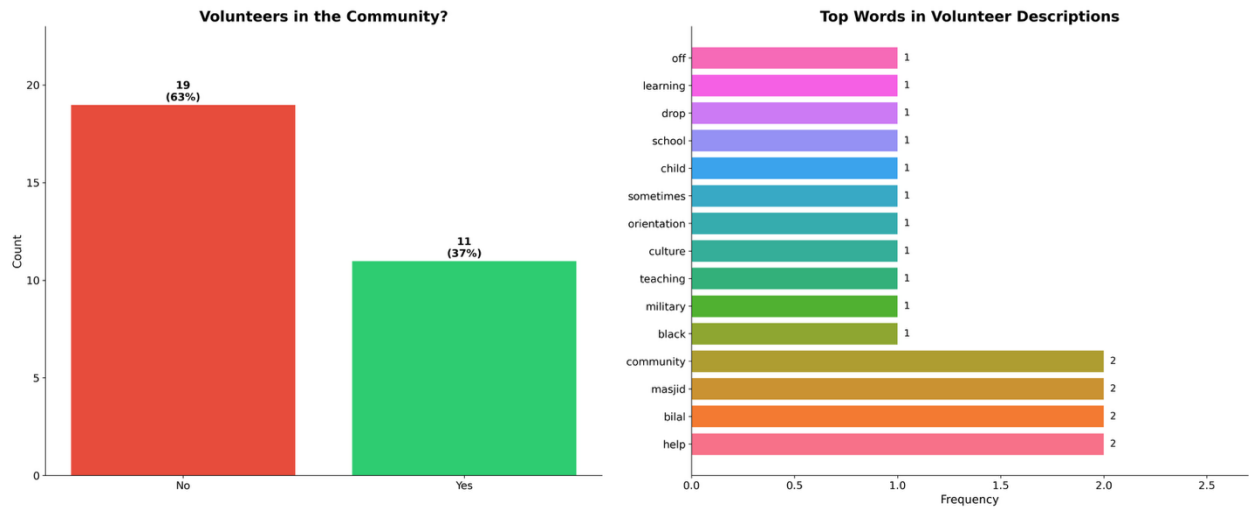


Figure 15: Community Volunteering

5.2 Statistical Description

Table 18 and Figure 16 present the statistical summary of the six key variables of this research, with a descriptive analysis of each of them. The statistics show measures of the mean, median, standard deviation, minimum, and maximum values, providing a clear background of the distribution and variation of the six variables across the survey data of the 30 respondents.

Table 18: Statistical Summary of Key Research Variables

Variable	Number	Mean	Median	Standard Deviation	Minimum	Maximum
Age	30	34.22	29.5	11.54	15	55
Education	30	2.83	3.0	0.99	1	4
English Proficiency	30	2.50	3.0	0.68	1	3
Income	29	1531	750	1057	300	3000
Time to find Job	26	2.27	2.0	1.31	1	5
Percentage of Income Spent Locally	29	56.88	63.0	27.41	12.5	88

Fig 16 • Statistical Summary of Survey Respondents (n=30)

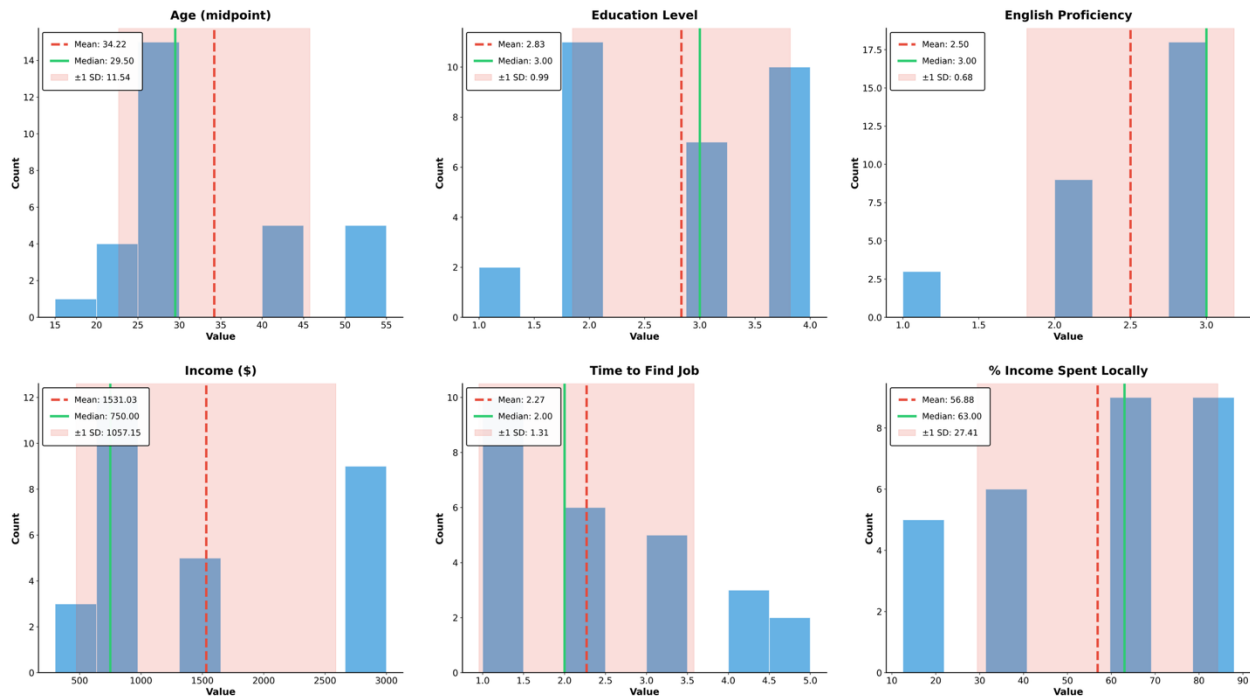


Figure 16: Statistical Summary of Respondents

5.2.1 Age:

The research participants' ages ranged from 15 to 55 years. The mean age was 34.22 years, with a median of 29.50 years and a standard deviation of 11.54 years. The gap between the mean and median reveals that while the majority of respondents represent the young-age group of 25 to 34 years old, a small proportion of older respondents increases the mean. This age distribution indicates that the research population is predominantly young, with a remarkable economic productivity capacity.

5.2.2 Educational Attainment:

On a scale of 1 to 4 (Middle High School to Graduate Degree), the mean education level was 2.83, and the median was 3.0, placing the typical respondent at a Bachelor's degree level. The standard deviation of 0.99 reflects a distribution around the Bachelor's and Graduate degrees. However, over 56% of respondents hold either a Bachelor's or a Graduate degree, indicating a strong educational background that fosters labor market integration in Syracuse.

5.2.3 English Proficiency:

Proficiency was measured on a scale of 1 (Basic) to 3 (Advanced). The mean was 2.50, and the median was 3.0, signifying that more than half of the respondents are Advanced English speakers. The low standard deviation of (0.68) suggests that most responses are grouped at the higher end of the scale, implying high linguistic competency across the sample. This high level of English Proficiency indicates the preparedness of immigrants for both the labor market and social integration.

5.2.4 Income:

Income represents the highest level of all variable variations. The mean income was \$1,531, while the median was \$750. The standard deviation of 1,057 highlights significant income variation. These statistics are impacted by the fact that 70% of respondents reported weekly earnings, while about 30% reported monthly totals. Consequently, the large standard deviation and the gap between the mean and median may be attributed to these differing units of measurement rather than purely reflecting income inequality within the sample.

5.2.5 Time to Find a Job: Measured on a scale of 1 to 5 (less than 3 months to 3 years), the mean was 2.27, and the median was 2.0, both corresponding to a job search duration of approximately six months. The standard deviation of 1.31 reveals significant variation; while some secured employment in under three months, others required up to three years.

5.2.6 Percentage of Income Spent Locally:

The mean percentage spent locally was 56.9%, and the median of 63.0%. The standard deviation of 27.4% shows considerable variation. While a small number of participants contribute very little to the local economy, the majority of the sample makes a significant local financial contribution.

5.3 Inter-Variable Analysis

This section analyzes the pair relationships between the four key variables of the study highlighted in the correlation matrix: Education, English Proficiency, Income, and the percentage of Income Spent Locally.

Table 19: Correlation Matrix of Key Economic Variables

Variable	Education	English Proficiency	Income	Percentage of income Spent Locally
Education	1.00	0.33	0.31	0.26
English Proficiency	0.33	1.00	0.17	0.13
Income	0.31	0.17	1	0.25
Percentage of Income Spent Locally	0.26	0.13	0.25	1.00

Note: Correlations were calculated using Pearson's r. Education was coded 1=Middle School to 4=Graduate degree. English proficiency was coded 1=Basic to 3=Advanced. Midpoint values coded the Income, and the Percentage Spent Locally was coded 1= $\leq 25\%$ to 4=76-100%.

Figure 17 . Correlation Matrix — Key Economic Variables (n=30)

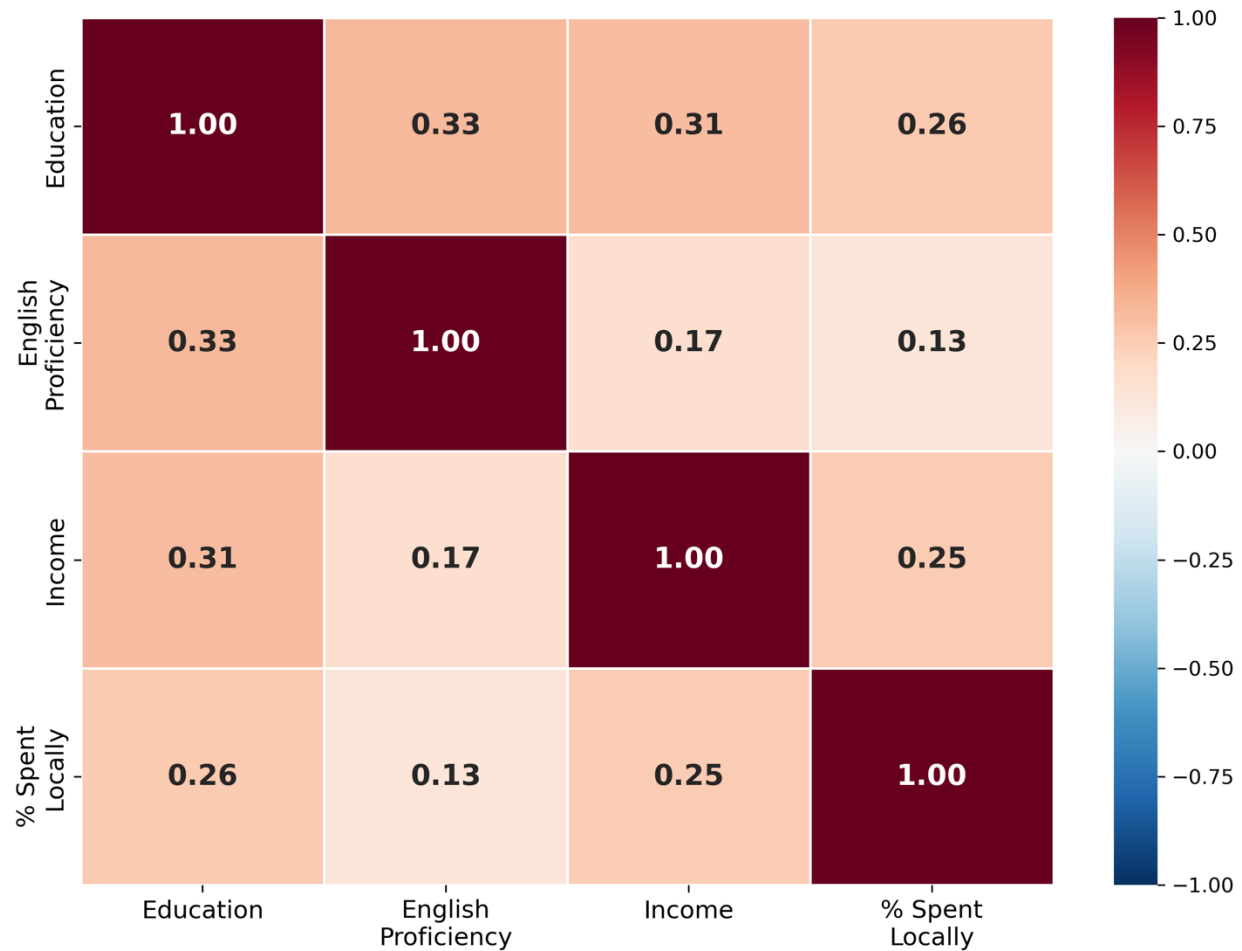


Figure 17: Correlation Matrix

Table 19 and Figure 17 show the correlation matrix of the four key variables of this study. The results reveal that the strongest relationship is between Education and English proficiency ($r=0.33$), indicating that a higher educational background is related to stronger linguistic competencies. Education also demonstrates a weak positive relationship with income ($r=0.31$), implying that higher education is associated with moderately higher earning ability among immigrants.

Income and percentage of income spent locally have a weak positive relationship ($r=0.25$), showing that higher income earners tend to spend more locally. Education similarly shows a weak positive relationship with local spending ($r=0.26$), suggesting that most educated immigrants have slightly more local spending. However, English proficiency shows very weak relationships with both income ($r=0.17$) and local spending ($r=0.13$), implying that linguistic skill alone does not

strongly determine economic assets in this research. All correlations are weak to moderate positive in strength ($r < 0.35$). This implies that economic integration of immigrants is a complex multidimensional process affected by multiple contextual reasons.

5.3.1 Education and English Proficiency:

The strongest relationship among the four key variables exists between education and English Proficiency ($r = 0.33$), indicating a weak-moderate positive correlation. This finding reveals that international immigrants with higher educational attainment tend to have stronger English-language proficiency.

As illustrated in Figure 7, Graduate degree respondents showed the highest concentration in the Advanced English proficiency category (70%), and no Graduate degree holder reported Basic English proficiency. High School holders showed the most varied distribution across all three proficiency levels, with 3 respondents reporting Basic proficiency, 2 intermediate, and 6 Advanced English proficiency. Middle School respondents reported no Advanced English capacity. Both respondents reported having intermediate English proficiency. These findings suggest that English training programs can play a meaningful role in helping reinforce the labor-market integration of immigrants in Syracuse.

5.3.2 Education and Income

Education and Income also show a strong relationship ($r = 0.31$), indicating a weak positive correlation. This finding reveals that immigrants with a higher level of educational background tend to earn slightly higher incomes, partially supporting Hypothesis 2 of this study.

As shown in Figure 13, Graduate degree respondents demonstrated the highest concentration in the income range of \$3,000 and more (40%), revealing that the highest income earners in this sample are predominantly those with Advanced academic backgrounds. High School holders were mostly concentrated in the \$500-\$1000 range (64%), representing the most combination of education and income. Bachelor's degree respondents showed the most varied income distribution, with representation across all income options. This shows that bachelor's degree income earners are less stable than the graduate degree holders.

Notably, Middle School holders were represented in both ranges of \$500-\$1,000 and \$1,000-\$2,000, stating that some immigrants with a lower educational background have moderate income levels. This finding supports Hypothesis 4, which assumed that immigrants across all educational levels make significant economic productivity and contribution.

5.3.3 Education and Local Spending

The relationship between education and percentage of income spent locally ($r=0.26$) represents a weak positive correlation. This finding reveals that the sample's more educated respondents tend to spend a slightly higher proportion of their income on local expenses, contributing more to the Syracuse local economy.

As shown in Figure 14, respondents across all educational levels demonstrated significant local spending, with the majority allocating more than 60% to local costs. Consequently, Graduate degree holders demonstrated the highest spending category (76%-100%), and High School holders showed the most varied distribution across all spending categories. These findings reveal that local spending responsibilities are influenced by several reasons beyond education only. Other factors are associated with family size or length of residence in Syracuse. This finding supports Hypothesis 4, which proposed that immigrants from all educational levels contribute to local spending, driven more by necessity related to day-to-day needs.

5.3.4 Income and Percentage of Income Spent Locally ($r=0.25$)

The relationship examined between income and the percentage spent locally ($r=0.25$) is a weak positive correlation. This finding shows that higher-income earners spend more of their earnings in the local economy. Even respondents who earn between \$500 and \$1,000, representing the largest group, were distributed across all spending levels. At the same time, those in the lowest income range, \$100-\$500, also showed significant local spending, with some of them allocating more than 50% of their modest earnings locally. This finding partially supports Hypothesis 3, which posits that higher-income immigrants spend a greater proportion of their income locally. Moreover, this result also strongly supports Hypothesis 4, which proposed that immigrants with lower income levels also make significant contributions to local spending. Therefore, the distribution of local spending across all income levels reveals that the economic contribution is general to all immigrants, supporting the economic participation of all types of immigrants regardless of their economic capacity. (See Figure 14)

5.3.5 English Proficiency and Income

The relationship between English proficiency and income ($r=0.17$) indicates a very weak positive correlation, suggesting that language proficiency does not have a strong direct influence on income productivity among immigrants. This tends to contradict what many usually believe, that English proficiency is a key factor in earning income.

As shown in Figure 6, Advanced English speakers were distributed across all income categories in the survey, with representation in both the lowest (\$100-\$500) and highest (\$3000 and more) income categories. Likewise, Intermediate and Basic English speakers demonstrated varied income distributions, with some earning relatively high earnings despite lower English language proficiency. This factor determines English proficiency as not being an exclusively relevant predictor of income level in this study. Therefore, this analysis reveals that other elements beyond English proficiency, such as refugee settlement, professional and social networks, can play a considerable role in earning income. This finding argues that policymakers should not only pretend that improving English proficiency is enough for labor-market integration. Other factors come into play, such as employment development opportunities, which are of utmost significance in terms of the economic rentability of international immigrants in Syracuse.

5.3.6 English Proficiency and Percentage of Income Spent Locally

The relationship between English proficiency and the percentage of income spent locally ($r=0.13$) indicates the weakest positive correlation among all variable pairs. This finding shows that English proficiency has no direct effect on local spending among immigrants in the sample.

As shown in Figures 6, 7, and 14, Intermediate English Speakers showed the highest accumulation in the 76%-100% local spending section, while advanced English speakers were concentrated in the 51%-75% section. Basic English speakers had the least local spending, with some using 25% or less of their earnings locally. This reflects that immigrants with low English proficiency can also make considerable contributions to the local economy. English proficiency is not necessarily a barrier to earning and investing in the local economy through their essential needs on housing, transportation, and groceries, revealing that the economic impact of immigrants covers all three language levels of the sample.

Figure 18 · Path Analysis — Economic Integration of Foreign-Born Residents in Syracuse (n=30)
All paths are positive — no paths reached statistical significance ($p > .05$)

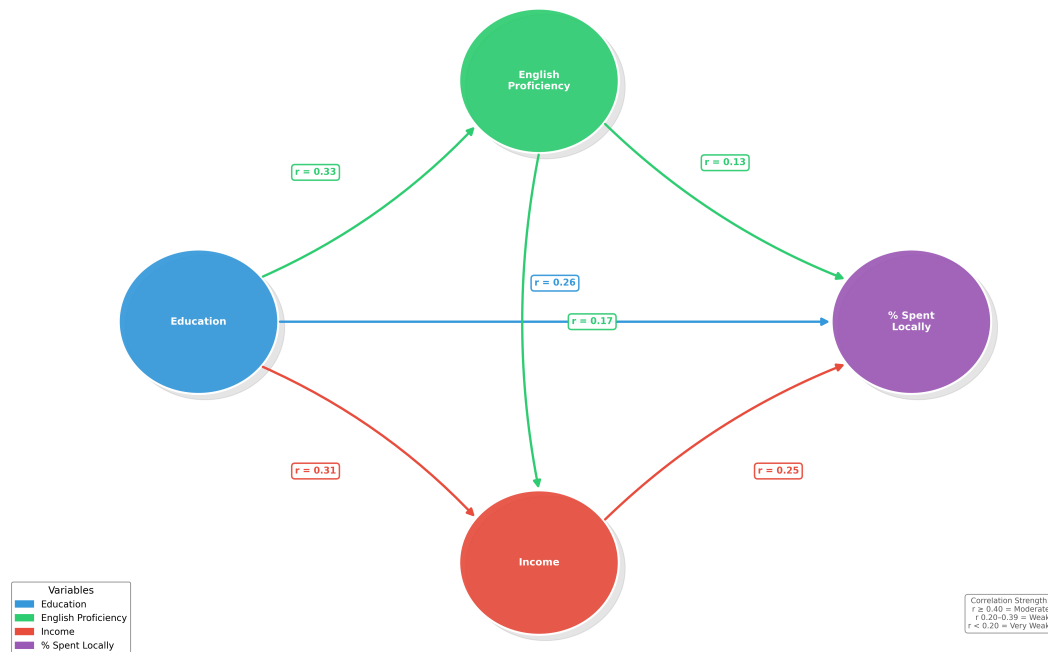


Figure 18: Path Analysis

5.4 Results Discussion

5.4.1 Demographic Information

This survey collected information from a target population of 30 participants. The sample is skewed toward males, who represent 63% of respondents, compared to 37% who are female, as shown in Figure 3. Half of the respondents (50%) are between 25 and 34 years old, indicating that the survey primarily recorded young immigrants with a mean of 34.22 years.

Additionally, a majority of respondents are married (63%) and parents (57%), suggesting a population largely focused on raising families. The participants originate from 17 different countries; Somalia is the most represented (27%), followed by Nigeria (10%), Turkey (6%), Burundi (6%), and Yemen (6%). The remaining represented nations each accounted for one participant (3%), including countries from across North America, Africa, Asia, and the Middle East, displaying the diverse multicultural identity of Syracuse International Immigrants.

5.4.2 Education and English Proficiency

The study population shows a relatively high level of educational attainment, as highlighted in Figure 6. Most participants attained high school (37%), followed by those with graduate degrees (33%) and bachelor's degrees (23%). Only 7% of the sample reported having only a basic

education. English proficiency among participants is notably high, 60% reported an advanced level, 30% intermediate, and only 10% basic. This high level of proficiency suggests a strong preparedness for integrating into the local workforce and the broader community. The heatmap in Figure 7 shows a positive relationship between education and English proficiency, with graduate degree majors mostly reporting Advanced English Proficiency.

5.4.3 Arrival Time in Syracuse

Most respondents in Syracuse arrived recently. However, the largest group arrived three years ago (30%), and the other groups arrived at four different times. While some arrived within one year, others arrived one year ago, and four years ago. Additionally, a few participants have a long-term residency background of 12, 20, or more than 20 years, indicating that some respondents have strong economic integration.

5.4.4 Profession

As shown in Figure 9, the employment section reveals that the largest share of immigrants works in the private sector (40%), while 30% are employed in the public sector. Furthermore, 17% identified as business owners, and another 12% specified roles that generally align with private-sector activity. Regarding the job search process, Figure 10 shows that 38 % of participants secured employment within three months of arrival, while 23% found work within six months. Conversely, 19% required a year or more to find a job. This disparity may suggest that individuals with higher education and English proficiency experience longer search periods due to higher professional expectations or the pursuit of specialized, well-paid positions. Furthermore, they can be constrained by a limited professional relationship or immigration status issues.

5.4.5 Income and Local Spending

As shown in Figure 12, the largest income group (41%) earns between \$500 and \$1,000. Additionally, 31% earn \$3,000 or more, while 17% earn between \$1,000 and \$2,000, as well as 10% of respondents earn between \$100 and \$500. The mean income of \$1,531 significantly exceeds the median of \$750, revealing a considerable income gap that can be justified through 70% of respondents receiving weekly payments.

In terms of local economic impact, as shown in Figure 14, over 60% of respondents spend more than 50% of their earnings locally. These findings suggest that immigrants contribute significantly to the local economy of Syracuse.

5.4.6 Civic Engagement

As shown in Figure 15, the survey reveals that 37% of respondents are actively involved in volunteer activities, including refugee associations, religious charities, school programs, and community groups. Those not involved in formal volunteering cited personal constraints and family responsibilities, highlighting their roles as working parents. These findings further support the conclusion that immigrants bear significant financial and social responsibilities and make meaningful contributions to the Syracuse community.

5.5 Policy Recommendations

Notably, respondents' time to find a job after arrival is the strongest indicator of local spending attitude in this study. However, it is suggested that:

- Public administration practitioners establish a job placement program for international immigrants, dedicated exclusively to their integration into the local workforce.
- Immigration Agencies and the local private and public sectors should work together to guarantee job placement for newly arrived immigrants.

The findings reveal that education and English proficiency have the strongest moderate positive correlation. The English language increases immigrants' social integration and economic opportunities. As shown in the findings, respondents who reported having basic English proficiency demonstrated the weakest economic rentability in the survey.

- It would be helpful to support and renovate English training programs for foreign-born residents to reinforce their rapid integration into the local community.

The survey results showed variation in income levels among immigrants. About 10% receive payments ranging from \$100 to \$500, whereas other respondents earn above \$3000. Regardless of whether immigrants perceive their income on a weekly or monthly basis, there is a large gap between earning brackets. The findings revealed a mean of \$1,531 and a median of \$750. This could be addressed as follows:

- Policymakers should implement financial support programs for low-income immigrants to help them alleviate the burden of local expenses
- They should also initiate targeted tax relief programs for low-income working families to reduce financial pressures during the early stages of their businesses or careers.

CONCLUSION

These findings demonstrate that international immigrants strengthen the Syracuse workforce, bolster local businesses, and enhance social cohesion. Survey research conducted with 30 respondents confirms that international immigrants contribute positively to the Syracuse economy through robust employment participation across both the public and private sectors, with 40% employed in the private sector, 30% in the public sector, and 17% as business owners. Notably, the fact that over 60% of respondents spend more than half of their income locally provides a direct stimulus to the local economic growth.

The results reveal that the primary factors fostering workforce integration are educational attainment and English proficiency. These variables demonstrated the strongest correlation in the study ($r=0.33$), confirming that higher education is related to stronger English proficiency, in line with Human Capital Theory (Becker, 1964) and (Mincer, 1974), with Human Capital Earnings Function leading to faster and more profitable labor market participation.

Furthermore, this study highlights the significant dual contribution of international immigrants to the economic and social fabric of Syracuse. While over 60 % respondents reinvest the majority of their financial gains into the local economy, 37% actively participate in civic engagement. This underscores their value as both economic and social stakeholders. Education also demonstrated a positive relationship with income ($r=0.31$) and local spending ($r=0.26$), indicating that human capital investment produces tangible economic return for both immigrants and the local community of Syracuse.

Ultimately, the findings suggest that immigrants represent a vital source of human capital to counter population decline and labor market deficits. These insights serve as a foundation for policy recommendations, such as improving the economic integration of immigrants and expanding English language training, that benefit foreign-born residents while cultivating impactful economic assets for the city of Syracuse.

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APPENDIX

Appendix A

Survey Instrument

Documentation of the questions used for the data collection

1. Demographics: Gender, Age Group, Marital Status, Country of origin.
2. Human Capital: Educational level, English Proficiency.
3. Migration History: year of Arrival in Syracuse, U.S. Citizenship Status.
4. Labor Market: Current Profession, Time to find First Job in Syracuse, Income Frequency
5. Economic Impact: Estimated Income Range, Percentage of income Spent locally (housing, food, services)
6. Social Integration: Community Volunteer Activity

Appendix B

Data Dictionary

This table shows the statistical analysis of the survey research.

Description	Values
Income brackets	1: \$ 100 - \$500 2: \$500 - \$1000 3: \$1000 - \$2000 4: \$3000+
Local spending level	1: 0-25% 2: 26-50% 3: 51-75% 4: 76-100%
Educational attainment	1: Middle School 2: High School 3: Bachelor's 4: Graduate Degree
Language proficiency	1: Basic 2: Intermediate 3: Advanced
Duration of residency	Numerical data of arrival years in Syracuse